Twelve Things to Notice and Write Down Before Your Husband's Care Arrangement Changes

What to look at in the days before the move and what to note beside each one, with no diagnosing.

You're already watching your husband closely. With the move a few days off, it helps to know which of the things you see are worth putting on paper. This guide names twelve and, for each, what to write.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. What any of it means is for his doctor, nurse or therapist to say, and your notes are what you bring them. The items on falls and the home follow the CDC's materials for family caregivers, the medicine items follow MedlinePlus, and the items on nights and on your own limits follow the Family Caregiver Alliance's discharge guide. The items about time on his own and about recurring concerns, and the wording about what to write down, are ours.

Moving about

1 Falls and unsteadiness [1]

NOTICE A fall, a stumble, a hand going out to the wall, or a day he seems unsteady to you.

WRITE DOWN The date, the time, where he was and what he was doing. Leave the reason to the clinician.

2 Getting up, and the tub and the toilet [2]

NOTICE What he holds, and whether someone gives him a hand, getting in and out of the tub and up from the toilet, the bed or a chair.

WRITE DOWN Each one, and the help he used.

3 What he says himself [1]

NOTICE Anything he says about being worried about falling, or about managing on his own.

WRITE DOWN His words as he said them, with the date.

Time on his own

4 The hours with nobody there

NOTICE The stretches of the planned week when no one would be with him, including the gap between one person leaving and the next arriving.

WRITE DOWN Each stretch, with the day and the times. Whether it is a concern is the care team's call.

5 Nights [3]

NOTICE Whether he gets up at night now, about how often, and whether someone is with him when he does.

WRITE DOWN The times, and who was up with him. Whether he needs someone at night is a question for the discharge team.

Medicines

6 The list [4]

NOTICE Whether there is one up-to-date list of his medicines and supplements and any allergies.

WRITE DOWN Where the list is, its date and who keeps it.

7 Who handles them [4]

NOTICE Who makes sure the right pill is taken at the right time today, who will after the move, and any difficulty you've seen along the way.

WRITE DOWN What happened and the day, as a fact. Change nothing; questions go to the prescriber or the pharmacist.

8 New instructions [4]

NOTICE Any instruction about his medicines given in the last few days, and whether you both understood it.

WRITE DOWN The instruction as it was given, who gave it, and what you'd like explained.

At home, if that's where he's going

9 Stairs, floors and walkways [2]

NOTICE Things left on the stairs, a loose handrail or one on only one side, throw rugs, cords across a walkway, furniture he has to walk around.

WRITE DOWN What it is and which room. You're listing what you see, not certifying the house.

10 The bedroom and the way to the bathroom [2]

NOTICE Whether the light near the bed is easy to reach, whether the path from the bed to the bathroom is dark, whether the tub or shower floor is slippery.

WRITE DOWN What you saw, and the time of day you looked.

Things that keep coming up

11 Recurring concerns

NOTICE Anything that keeps returning with his eating and drinking, getting to the bathroom or his skin, or any other health concern that comes back.

WRITE DOWN What you saw and the date, with no explanation attached. It goes to the care team as it is.

You

12 Your own days and nights [3] [5]

NOTICE How much sleep you're getting, what else you're responsible for, and any task you're expected to do that nobody has shown you.

WRITE DOWN A plain, honest note. The discharge staff are meant to hear about a caregiver's limits and about any training you need.

When to call instead of write

If he has fallen, is worried about falling or seems unsteady, the CDC's advice to family caregivers is to tell a healthcare provider right away. For anything else on this list that worries you today, call the number you were given; Medicare's checklist tells families to write down the names and phone numbers of people to call with questions or concerns. If you weren't given one, ask for it.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these mean, how serious they are, whether your husband can be on his own, or whether the arrangement is safe. The care team does that, and your notes help them do it.

Ready for the next step?

You've noticed, and you've written it down. The care interview asks about the same areas in order, along with who is helping and what the care team has already said, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Family Caregivers: Protect Your Loved Ones from Falling (STEADI brochure, 2018)
2. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Check for Safety: A Home Fall Prevention Checklist for Older Adults (STEADI brochure, 2018)
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
4. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Caregiving - medication management: MedlinePlus Medical Encyclopedia
5. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
